The Comfortable Prison

The Matrix and the Philosophers

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Early in *The Matrix*, Neo pulls a book off his shelf, opens it, and reveals that it has been hollowed out to hide the contraband software he sells on the side. If you blinked, you missed the title. It is *Simulacra and Simulation*, by the French philosopher Jean Baudrillard. The hollowed-out section opens at the chapter "On Nihilism," a word that takes us back to the start of our arc. Nihilism was the radical creed of young Russians in the 1860s, part of the world that Dostoevsky's Underground Man was reacting to.

This is not a random prop. The Wachowskis reportedly asked their lead actors to read Baudrillard before filming. Later, when Morpheus shows Neo what is left of the real world, he greets him with a line lifted straight from the book: "Welcome to the desert of the real."

Where does the film fit in our arc? With *1984*, we looked at control through fear, surveillance, and the rewriting of the record. *The Matrix* moves us a step further: control of reality itself, so complete that the controlled don't know it is happening. Our lens for this class is the analysis of societal control: who or what is controlling society, and how?

Baudrillard is the philosopher the film invites to the party. I want to bring along a second guest, Gilles Deleuze, who never appears on screen but, I think, explains the film's machinery even better. Roughly speaking, Baudrillard tells us about the illusion, and Deleuze tells us about the system running it. Between them, they help with the question that keeps nagging at us in this course: what does defiance look like when control no longer feels like control?

Baudrillard: when the copy replaces the real

Baudrillard's big claim is that modern life, saturated with media, advertising, and entertainment, has produced what he calls *hyperreality*. Images and signs used to point to something real behind them. Now, he says, they mostly point to other images and signs, and the copy starts to feel more real than any original.

He illustrates this with a one-paragraph story by Jorge Luis Borges, "On Exactitude in Science", about an empire whose mapmakers draw a map so detailed that it covers the entire territory, point for point. In Baudrillard's twist on the fable, the map is eventually all anyone sees, and the land underneath quietly rots away. The rotting land is his "desert of the real."

> **A physicist's aside.** The map fable Baudrillard referenced has a curious echo in the history of mathematics. In the 1820s, Carl Friedrich Gauss led a land survey of the Kingdom of Hanover. To achieve high accuracy, he had to take the curvature of the earth into account, and wrestling with

that problem helped inspire his work on curved surfaces. That work was a founding contribution to differential geometry, which, extended by Bernhard Riemann, became the mathematics behind Einstein's general theory of relativity. Like the maps in the fable, Gauss's maps kept getting closer and closer to the territory.

As a mathematical physicist, I have often felt that the mathematical model, the physics of bendy maps with quantum-mechanical uncertainty added in, is actually the deeper reality underneath the everyday world we live in. So I am tempted to turn Baudrillard on his head. Maybe the map is more real than the territory.

A mathematician's aside. The hyperreality Baudrillard wrote about has an echo in modern mathematics, though it takes a bit of history to get there. After Isaac Newton and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz independently invented calculus, it took mathematicians nearly two centuries to put it on a fully rigorous footing. Newton's formulation, closer to the modern idea of a limit, turned out to be the easier one to make rigorous. Part of that work was a precise construction of the real numbers, built step by step from the whole numbers.

In our second class, I added a verbal "footnote" to our discussion of "$2 + 2 = 4$" in *1984*: Bertrand Russell did a great deal of work to establish rigorously that $1 + 1 = 2$. (In *Principia Mathematica*, written with Alfred North Whitehead, the proof arrives several hundred pages in.) Russell's work, including the paradox that bears his name, helped lead to a rigorous foundation for set theory, within which even the whole numbers can be constructed.

That rigorous underpinning helped Kurt Gödel in his foundational work on logical incompleteness and on the continuum hypothesis, a question about the hierarchy of infinite sets. Gödel's work in turn was foundational for Alan Turing's work on computability and logic. Turing has been called the father of theoretical computer science. He opened the way to the digital world whose takeover we are now struggling with.

Logic building on Gödel's work also led, in the 1960s, to a rigorous definition of the *hyperreal numbers* by Abraham Robinson. There are infinitely many hyperreal numbers larger than zero but smaller than every positive real number. Their construction finally put Leibniz's formulation of calculus, with its infinitesimals, on a rigorous footing as well.

My mind has spent much time spinning not just on the underlying reality of physics, but on the underlying reality of mathematics as well.

The Matrix takes the fable and plays it straight: a perfect simulation of 1999 that the people inside take for reality. (Why 1999? Agent Smith tells us it was the peak of human civilization. Make of that what you will.)

Control through comfort. Here is where Baudrillard earns his place in a course on mind control. In *1984*, control comes through fear, surveillance, and the rat cage. In Baudrillard's world, control works by surrounding people with so many signs that there is no solid ground left from which to question them. Nobody needs to chain your mind if you are perfectly happy where you are.

Cypher makes the point concrete. He sits in the simulation, cuts into a steak he knows doesn't exist, and decides he would rather go back in: "Ignorance is bliss." He isn't tricked. He chooses. I accept that many people might *prefer* the illusion. In fact, I often do. But it makes me worry: am I contributing to, or being swept up in, our collectively "checking out"? Adapting a famous quote of Benjamin Franklin, changing "Liberty" to "Freedom" and "Safety" to "Comfort," and turning the whole thing into a question, I would ask:

> Do those who would give up essential Freedom, to purchase a little temporary Comfort, deserve either Freedom or Comfort?

Where the film and the philosopher part ways. Here is the twist. Baudrillard didn't much like the movie. In a 2003 interview with the French magazine *Le Nouvel Observateur*, he called it the kind of film about the Matrix that the Matrix itself could have produced.

His complaint was that the film keeps an old-fashioned structure, going all the way back to Plato's cave. There is a real world (the ruined surface, the city of Zion) waiting behind the illusion, and anyone brave enough to take the red pill can wake up into it.

For Baudrillard, there is no such exit. Hyperreality has no "real" waiting outside. The heroic story of waking up, complete with a chosen One, is itself a comforting myth, one more product the system is happy to sell us, with popcorn. Defiance, for him, looks bleaker and stranger. It is less like revolution and more like refusal, rather like Dostoevsky's Underground Man: shrugging, going silent, making gestures the system can't absorb or answer.

Deleuze: from walls to codes

If Baudrillard tells us what has happened to reality, Deleuze tells us how power now works. He does it in a short essay from 1990, "Postscript on the Societies of Control", which is only about five pages long.

Deleuze starts from the work of Michel Foucault, whose *Discipline and Punish* gave us the Panopticon we met in our class on *1984*. Foucault described what he called *disciplinary societies*. In these, power works through enclosed institutions: the prison, the school, the factory, the hospital, the barracks. Each one shapes you inside its walls, and over a lifetime you graduate from one enclosure to the next. Big Brother's Oceania is discipline cranked up to eleven.

Deleuze argues that we have been moving into *societies of control*. Power no longer needs the walls. It works through continuous, flexible monitoring: credit scores, passwords, endless training and retraining, the performance review that never quite ends. His way of putting it: discipline is a **mold** that presses you into a fixed shape, while control is **modulation**, adjusting itself to you constantly and invisibly.

Deleuze was writing before the takeover of smartphones, social media, and everything going online. He was, prophetically, giving us a guide to understanding and coping with being sucked into the digital world.

Once you have that picture in mind, the film starts to look like a diagram of it.

The pods versus the simulation. The pods where human bodies lie are pure enclosure, as confining as any prison Foucault ever studied. But the real work of control happens inside the simulation, where people stroll around, go to work, and feel entirely unconfined. That is Deleuze's central point. The most effective control is the kind that never feels like confinement.

Codes and access. Deleuze says that what matters in a control society isn't your signature or your ID number. It is a code, a password that grants or denies access. The film's plot turns on exactly this: the access codes to Zion's mainframe locked in Morpheus's head, the crew hacking in and out, and those ringing landlines that serve as exits.

"Dividuals." Deleuze suggests that the individual gets broken down into *dividuals*: data points, accounts, samples, streams to be managed. The film's image of human beings farmed as batteries is a literal version of this. Each person has been reduced to an energy output.

The Agents. Agent Smith can take over anyone's body at any moment. Control here isn't located in a guard or a wall. It can pop up anywhere in the network. Deleuze contrasts the old disciplinary society, a burrowing mole that tunnels from enclosure to enclosure, with the new control society, a serpent that coils and slides through everything. The Agents, in their identical sunglasses, are serpents.

What Deleuze adds on defiance

This is where the two thinkers really part company. Baudrillard leaves little room for resistance, since there is no outside to escape to. Deleuze is more upbeat, or at least less gloomy. He writes that there is no need to fear or to hope, only to look for new weapons. In an interview with the Italian philosopher Antonio Negri, he suggested that resistance might take the form of "circuit breakers": small pockets of silence and non-communication that slip out from under the network's constant monitoring.

Neo and his crew fit this picture rather well. They don't attack the Matrix from some pure outside. They are hackers who use the system's own codes against it, bending its rules from within. Read through Deleuze, the film's real hope lies less in a grand awakening than in the knack for finding cracks in a system that isn't going away.

Both thinkers leave us with a practical question that neither of them answers: if there is no red pill, what are the rest of us supposed to do? That question is the subject of the companion essay, "No One Is Coming."

Questions for discussion

- Baudrillard says there is no "real world" to wake up into. Is he right, or is there still something real underneath the simulation?
- The film keeps Plato's structure of a real world behind the illusion. Is that a flaw, as Baudrillard thought, or a strength?
- Is Deleuze's picture of control, modulation without walls, a better description of our world than Orwell's Big Brother? Or do we live with both?

Extra Credit Appendix on the sequel "The Matrix Reloaded"

The sequel to *The Matrix*, *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003), moves the story much closer to both of our philosophers.

Near the end, Neo meets the Architect, the program that designed the Matrix, in a room full of television screens. The Architect explains, at considerable length, that this is not the first Matrix but the sixth. Each earlier version failed because some humans rejected it. The machines' solution was to *build rejection into the system*. "The One" and the free city of Zion are themselves part of the design: a planned outlet that gathers the rebels in one place, which the machines periodically wipe out before restarting the cycle.

The Baudrillard reading. This is very close to Baudrillard's warning that there is no outside. The red pill, the awakening, the resistance all turn out to belong to the simulation's own machinery. Even the chosen One, the hero of the first film, is a product of the system. The sequel takes Baudrillard's suspicion of the savior story to its conclusion. The escape hatch was installed by the landlord. And, you may remember, in *1984* the landlord of Winston and Julia's hideaway room, Mr. Charrington, turned out to be an agent of Big Brother's Thought Police.

The Deleuze reading. Six versions of the Matrix, each adjusted to absorb the last "anomaly," are modulation in its purest form. The system doesn't crush deviation; it learns from it and ships an update. Resistance becomes data for version 7.0.

Question for discussion: If control can absorb every act of resistance and use it to improve itself, what would a genuinely "new weapon," in Deleuze's phrase, look like?